“Does Mom Have Too Much to Qualify?”

And other questions families ask about Medicaid when planning ahead, with plain general answers and who to ask about Mom.

Whenever Medicaid comes up at a family dinner, everyone has a different answer, and most of them start with “I heard.” These are the questions that come up most, answered in general terms from public sources.

None of the answers is about Mom in particular. Where a question needs someone who knows her state and her situation, the answer says who to ask.

1 Does Mom have too much to qualify?

Nobody can tell from a total, and that includes this page. The Administration for Community Living explains that when a state looks at assets, some are counted and others are excluded, that many aren't counted at all, and that the amount of countable assets a person can have varies from state to state. Income is handled in a similar way: a state counts some of it, but not all. So the honest general answer is that it depends on the state and on what her income and assets are, not only on how much. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know how Mom's own income and assets compare with the rules in her state. That comparison is the review your Medicaid planner does.

2 Would Mom be eligible if she ever needed long-term care?

That isn't something a guide, a relative or a website can say. States take the applications and make the eligibility decisions, and they look at general requirements, financial requirements and, for long-term care services, a person's care needs. The answer depends on her state and on her situation at the time. What a family can do ahead of time is write down where she stands today, with a date on it. [2] [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you'd like someone to go through Mom's situation area by area. Your Medicaid planner can do that, and an elder law attorney can take the legal questions that come out of it.

3 Why does everyone we ask have a different answer?

Often because each of them is describing a different state or a different year. Medicaid's overall rules are federal, but states have considerable leeway in how they run their programs, so eligibility rules and covered services vary from state to state. The National Institute on Aging adds that benefits and eligibility requirements can change over time. What was true for a neighbor's father may not be true for Mom. [3] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want the answer for Mom's state. The Administration for Community Living calls the State Medical Assistance office the best source for how to qualify there, and your Medicaid planner can review how Mom's picture compares with those rules.

4 Doesn't Medicare pay for long-term care?

No. Medicare.gov says it in those words: “Medicare doesn't pay for long-term care.” Long-term care is mostly help with the basic personal tasks of everyday life, like dressing and bathing, and Medicare and most health insurance don't cover it. Medicaid offers benefits not normally covered by Medicare, such as nursing home care and personal care services, for people who meet their state's rules. [5] [6] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're not sure what Mom's own coverage includes. Her plan can tell you, and the National Institute on Aging points families to the State Health Insurance Assistance Program (SHIP), which offers one-on-one counseling on Medicare, Medicaid and related programs.

5 Is it only about money?

No. Care needs are assessed separately. The Administration for Community Living explains that a medical specialist in the state evaluates a person's needs, and that Medicaid will not cover long-term care services for someone who doesn't meet its functional criteria, regardless of financial eligibility. For your notes, that means how Mom is doing day to day belongs beside the finances. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** Mom's needs change and you want to know how her state would look at them.

6 What about her house?

It depends on the state and the situation, which makes it a good question to take to a professional. In general terms, a state may ask a homeowner to document the home's fair market value and any loans on it, and states have varying rules about home equity. Estate recovery, which often gets mixed in with this question, is a separate matter: it concerns repayment from a person's estate after their death, not whether they qualify. [2] [7] [8]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the house is part of Mom's picture. Bring what you know about the deed and any loans to your Medicaid planner, and take questions about ownership or estate recovery to an elder law attorney.

7 What changes if Mom is married?

The picture then includes both spouses, and separate provisions come into it. Medicaid.gov describes spousal impoverishment rules meant to keep the spouse who stays at home, called the community spouse, from being left with little or no income or resources when the other needs long-term care. Under them, a certain amount of the couple's combined resources is protected for the spouse at home. The amounts are updated from year to year, and what they would mean for a particular couple isn't something a general page can say. [9] [10] [11]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** Mom is married, or her marital status has changed. Write down what is in whose name and bring it to your Medicaid planner.

8 What could prevent or delay her qualifying?

In general, the same areas a review looks at: care needs, income, assets, the home, a spouse, and what has changed hands. On the last of these, a state may ask whether any assets were given away, and its Medicaid agency reviews a period before the application for transfers. The Administration for Community Living also notes that a decision may take longer when required documents aren't provided on time. Whether any of this applies to Mom depends on her state and the details. [2] [11]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** something of Mom's has been given away, sold to a relative or put in another name, or the family is thinking about it. Write down what and when, leave things as they are, and ask your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney before anything is done.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Mom herself: whether she would qualify, what a state would count, or what anything in her history means. Those answers depend on her state and her situation, and they come from a professional who has looked at both. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions, and you know which ones only a professional can answer for Mom. The planning interview is where the questions become about your family: it asks about your situation one part at a time and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Medicaid Eligibility
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Applying for Medicaid
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Medicaid
4. National Institute on Aging, Paying for Long-Term Care
5. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Long Term Care Coverage
6. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Medicaid
7. Justice in Aging, Medicaid Home and Community-Based Services for Older Adults: A Primer
8. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Medicaid Estate Recovery
9. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Spousal Impoverishment
10. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Eligibility Policy
11. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Glossary